the previous night and, to be honest, I wasn't in great condition. Looking somewhat dishevelled after only a few hours' rest, I sunk into my seat on the aisle and immediately fell fast asleep.

This much-needed snooze was abruptly interrupted by someone gently poking me in the ribs.

'Excuse me, AB,' said a man in his mid-forties.

'Yes,' I said, still somewhat blurred in thought and speech.

'I think we're going to land in Cape Town in around 15 minutes and I would like to speak to you,' he said. 'Please feel free to stop me at any time, and I'll obviously leave you alone.'

'OK,' I said, wondering where this conversation would lead.

I recognised him. We had met once before, three months earlier at a dinner with a mutual friend, Louis Vorster, the outstanding former batsman for Transvaal and Northerns, and, as the plane began its descent into Cape Town International, this virtual stranger proceeded to tear me apart. He said he knew a few players in the squad and, from what he'd heard, he believed I had huge potential, but that I was wasting my talent. He said I appeared more interested in the next party than in my next innings.

'Let me know if and when you want to get serious and start getting organised,' he concluded.

I was taken aback. Some of what he had said was exaggerated and unfair, but some not. By now, our plane had come to a halt and other passengers were collecting their hand luggage and disembarking.

As he made his way to the exit of the plane, my mind was racing. I didn't know much about this individual, but he had worked at the top level of South African sport for more than 20 years, first as a journalist and sports editor, then as a CEO in rugby and then as a general manager in broadcasting. He seemed to know what he was talking about and, although I wasn't going to admit as much to him, I did need to be better organised off the field. So I made my way off the plane and started to search for him in the baggage-claim area.